the Modi government cited technical flaws in the report



In 2018, Union home minister **Rajnath Singh** promised to include caste count in the 2021 Census. The government later declined to do so, citing logistical issues

When the Bihar assembly passed a resolution to conduct a caste survey, all BJP MLAs supported it. But in Odisha, both BJP and Congress opposed such a resolution

THE CONGRESS



Jawaharlal Nehru opposed a caste census in 1951. Indira Gandhi and **Rajiv Gandhi** ignored the Mandal Commission report. When V.P. Singh implemented the OBC reservation, Rajiv termed it as an attempt to divide the country along caste lines



In 2006, the **Manmohan Singh** government announced 27 per cent reservation for OBCs in admission to central educational institutions. The Socio Economic and Caste Census (SECC) that his government conducted as part of the 2011 census fell victim to internal dissensions over its release



Going against the party's traditional stand against a nationwide caste census, **Rahul Gandhi** has now demanded a rejig of the reservation structure across the country to provide reservation proportionate to the share of population

THE TMC



Though all parties of the INDIA bloc have demanded a caste census, the TMC is reportedly reluctant. The OBC list prepared under the **Mamata Banerjee** government has come under the scanner as 118 groups among the 179 OBC communities in Bengal are Muslims. Any change in the current structure may antagonise Muslims, TMC's strong vote bank, allege critics

CASTE-BASED PARTIES

Most caste-based parties like the SP and BSP in Uttar Pradesh and RJD and JD(U) in Bihar have demanded a caste count. They argue that OBCs account for over 60 per cent of the population and thus the 27 per cent quota is inadequate

a 'jumla' like the women's reservation bill, to be implemented sometime in the future and riddled with numerous ifs and buts. There are also inconsistencies in the official classification of some caste groups. The Jats, for instance, enjoy OBC status in Rajasthan but not in Haryana or in the central list. In states like Karnataka, Rajasthan, MP, Tamil Nadu and Maharashtra, even some Brahmins find a place in the list of OBCs. In the South, Reddys are backward in Karnataka but not in other states.

Besides, several dominant caste groups, such as the Patidars in Gujarat, the Marathas in Maharashtra and the Jats in Haryana have been agitating, often violently, demanding OBC status. Any count without resolving these contentious demands may create a bigger mess for the Centre. "A nationwide caste census is not feasible. Caste count must happen at the state level," says Prof. Bajaj.

The BJP itself is open to the idea of states conducting a caste census but only for the purpose of "designing welfare programmes better". And so BJP's OBC Morcha chief Laxman wants every state to conduct a caste census, while former Bihar deputy chief minister Sushil Kumar Modi even claims credit for the Bihar caste survey saying the decision was taken when the BJP was part of the coalition government led by the JD(U).

Ruling governments at the Centre have always been reluctant to conduct a nationwide caste census, both during the UPA regime, and now under the National Democratic Alliance rule, afraid perhaps of a redux of the 1990 insurrection. That perhaps explains why successive governments have hesitated from releasing the results of the 2011 SECC data. In 2021, the Modi government rejected a demand from the Maharashtra government to share the data, saying it was "unusable". It's a different matter that the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India had, in 2016, informed the Standing Committee on Rural Development that 98.87 per cent of the data on individual caste and religion in SECC was "error-free".

After over three decades, Mandal's conundrums have returned to haunt the country's socio-political landscape. Caste injustice is an unfortunate reality in India and countering it requires a sustained and concerted effort to raise awareness as well as hone sensibilities. A headcount may well provide a more accurate picture of socio-economic disparities, but the demand for it, or its rejection, should not flow from short-term electoral imperatives. The social justice agenda of the country has long been held hostage to vote bank politics. Mandal 2.0 seems to be headed in the same direction. ■

with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Amitabh Srivastava and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar